

Where to Begin When Your Life Is in Ruins

Ryan Chase · Emmaus Road Church, Sioux Falls, SD · October 4, 2026

Ezra 3 PRIMARY TEXT	45 min SERMON LENGTH	47 SCRIPTURE REFERENCES	32 SECTIONS WE MAPPED
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THE SERMON IN ONE SENTENCE

Restoration and renewal always begin with a return to right worship—reconciliation with God through atonement for sin is the necessary starting point for rebuilding any ruined life.

Summary

Ryan Chase preaches from Ezra 3 to answer a pressing question: when your life is a mess—whether from accumulated sin or yesterday's failure—where do you even begin? The returning Jewish exiles provide the answer: you start with worship. Before rebuilding the temple, they rebuilt the altar and offered burnt offerings, prioritizing reconciliation with God through atonement. This pattern, Chase argues, reveals God's consistent method of renewal across Scripture and history. Worship is the necessary starting point because atonement for sin is humanity's most urgent need, fulfilled in Christ's once-for-all sacrifice. But worship doesn't stay internal—it propels outward action in the world, as the exiles moved from altar to temple construction. And worship responds with grateful celebration at every milestone, no matter how small. The sermon's pastoral force comes from its insistence that the gospel must function practically: when you fail on Tuesday morning, run to the cross through repentance and faith, let worship reorient your heart, then take the next step of obedient action.

YOUR SERMON PAGE

<https://sermonsteward.com/SGchurch/EmmausRoadSiouxFalls/sermons/where-to-begin-when-you-r-life-is-in-ruins-ezra-3-2026-10-04>

THIS WEEK ACROSS THE REGION

<https://sermonsteward.com/SGchurch/MidwestNorthwest/10-4-26/>

Eight Sovereign Grace churches, one Sunday: Scripture, themes, and How We Said It.

What We Noticed

Doctrinal loci

- **Soteriology** — The sermon centers on atonement as humanity's most urgent need, tracing it from Old Testament burnt offerings to Christ as the propitiation God Himself provided to satisfy His own justice and secure favor forever.
- **Doxology / Worship** — The entire sermon structure argues that worship is the priority, power, and response in restoration—beginning with reconciliation, producing action in the world, and celebrating every evidence of grace.
- **Sanctification** — Chase applies the gospel practically to daily failures, teaching that repentance and faith in Christ's finished work produce renewed hearts that then take the next step of obedient action.
- **Covenant Theology** — The sermon traces God's pattern of renewal through Israel's history—from exodus commemoration to Solomon's temple to exile and return—showing God's faithfulness to keep His promises and work through the same methods across covenants.

Themes

Worship as the starting point for restoration

Atonement and propitiation in Christ

The gospel's practical function in daily life

God's pattern of working from internal to external

Celebrating small beginnings and rejecting nostalgia

Christian optimism grounded in resurrection hope

Editor notes

- The sermon's three-part structure (priority, power, response of worship) creates unusual rhetorical unity, with each major section building on a different aspect of the same controlling metaphor rather than merely sequential exposition.
- Chase's extended tracing of the chorus 'for he is good, for his steadfast love endures forever' through Israel's history to Jeremiah's promise creates a powerful demonstration of God's attention to detail in promise-keeping.

- The personal testimony in unit 24 about failing to thank God for answered prayer functions as more than illustration—it models pastoral vulnerability and reinforces the sermon's application in real time.
- The polemic against pietism (unit 19) and nostalgia (units 26-27) shows pastoral courage to address both contemplative withdrawal and cultural romanticism as equal threats to faithful action.

Writing Prompts

Concepts from each main point you could explore further in your own reading and writing.

1. Why Atonement Must Come Before Action

The returning exiles rebuilt the altar before the temple, offered sacrifices before laying foundations. This sequence isn't arbitrary—it reveals that reconciliation with God through atonement is the necessary starting point for any meaningful work in the world. The article would explore why attempting to fix external circumstances before seeking internal restoration with God always fails, and how this pattern appears throughout Scripture.

FROM: UNITS 9-11, EXPOSITION OF EZRA 3:2-3 AND THE THEOLOGICAL NECESSITY OF PROPITIATION

2. The Expulsive Power of Gospel-Centered Worship

When you lose patience on Monday morning, your real problem isn't time management—it's worship. This article would unpack how thinking rightly about God in the moment of failure (worshiping at the cross) actually pushes out sinful attitudes through what the Puritans called 'the expulsive power of a new affection.' Practical theology for Tuesday afternoon failures.

FROM: UNITS 14-15, APPLICATION OF RUNNING TO THE CROSS AND THE HYPOTHETICAL MONDAY MORNING SCENARIO

3. Why Your Worship Should Produce Calluses

True piety cannot stay in the heart—it comes out through the hands. The exiles moved from altar to action, from atonement to organized work on the temple. This article would explore the biblical pattern of worship necessarily producing work in the world, warning against pietism's false dichotomy between devotion and action, and calling readers to ask: what obedient action is my worship producing?

FROM: UNITS 17-19, THE TRANSITION FROM WORSHIP TO WORK AND THE THEOLOGICAL DISTINCTION BETWEEN PIETY AND PIETISM

4. Just Start: The Biblical Antidote to Overwhelm

Facing overwhelming ruin? Ask one question: what is the next step of obedient faith? This article would address spiritual and practical paralysis by showing how the exiles didn't solve everything at once—they started with the altar, then moved to the foundation, then to the walls. Application for readers drowning in accumulated responsibilities, broken relationships, or patterns of sin.

FROM: UNIT 20, APPLICATION ABOUT PROCRASTINATION AND ASKING WHAT IS THE NEXT STEP

5. The Discipline of Celebrating Incomplete Grace

The exiles threw a worship party at the foundation-laying—before the temple was built, before the walls were raised, before restoration was complete. Jeremiah had promised they would sing 'for he is good, for his steadfast love endures forever' again in Jerusalem, and they did. This article would teach readers to actively look for and thank God for every evidence of grace rather than waiting for completion, combating the ingratitude that poisons spiritual growth.

FROM: UNITS 22-25, EXPOSITION OF THE FOUNDATION CELEBRATION AND APPLICATION TO THANKING GOD FOR PROGRESS

6. Don't Despise the Day of Small Things

The older generation wept because the new foundation didn't match Solomon's glory—and God rebuked them through the prophets. This article would explore the spiritual danger of nostalgia, whether for a previous era of church history or a season of personal faithfulness, and contrast it with Christian optimism grounded in the resurrection: the belief that God's promises guarantee the future will exceed the past.

FROM: UNITS 26-28, EXPOSITION OF VERSE 12 AND THEOLOGICAL CLAIM ABOUT RESURRECTION-GROUNDED HOPE

7. How to Know If the Gospel Actually Functions in Your Life

Many Christians affirm the gospel theoretically but don't run to it practically when they fail. This article would provide diagnostic questions: When you sin on Thursday afternoon, does your heart instinctively move toward the cross through repentance and faith? Does worship reorient your affections and then produce obedient action? Or does the gospel remain a Sunday doctrine disconnected from Tuesday morning reality?

FROM: UNIT 14, APPLICATION CALLING FOR THE GOSPEL TO BECOME FUNCTIONALLY CENTRAL IN DAILY LIFE

Congregation Resources

The same resources published on your sermon page.

Small-Group Discussion

When the exiles returned to Jerusalem and saw the ruins, what was the first thing they did before attempting any reconstruction work, and what does this tell us about their understanding of where restoration must begin?

- ↳ Why do you think they prioritized the altar and sacrifice before even laying the temple foundation?

EZRA 3:2-3

Walk through the sequence of events in Ezra 3: altar, daily offerings, then the foundation of the temple. What does this progression reveal about the order in which God restores a ruined life?

EZRA 3:1-13

The sermon emphasized that atonement for sin is 'every human being's most urgent need.' How does the old covenant system of burnt offerings and atoning sacrifices point us toward understanding our deepest problem, and what does that problem actually require?

- ↳ What changes when we grasp that Jesus is the propitiation God Himself provided?

LEVITICUS 1

The sermon contrasted true piety with pietism—the difference between private devotion that naturally flows into public obedience versus private devotion that stays locked in the heart. Where are you tempted to create that false divide in your own life right now?

- ↳ What would it look like this week for your worship to actually move 'out through your hands' into the world around you?

When some of the older exiles wept at the sight of the temple foundation—because it was so much smaller than Solomon's temple—the people's response was to 'shout with a loud voice.' What does this tell us about how we should respond when God works through small, humble beginnings rather than grand ones?

- ↳ How does this challenge the way you might be tempted to measure whether God is really at work in your life or church?

EZRA 3:12-13

Think about an area of your life right now that feels 'in ruins'—whether through your own sin, broken relationships, or neglected responsibilities. Based on what we see in Ezra 3, what is the first step you need to take, and what does that step require from you spiritually?

- ↳ Who in your community could you invite to walk through that first step of reconciliation with you?

Daily Readings

This week we walk through the pattern of restoration: from atonement and reconciliation with God, through worship that compels action, to the confident hope that God works through humble beginnings.

Monday [Leviticus 16:30](#)

The Day of Atonement in Leviticus shows Israel's deepest need: reconciliation with God through the covering of sin. The exiles in Ezra 3 grasped this urgently—they built the altar **before** the temple because they knew that without atonement, no building or work matters. We, too, begin our renewal not with self-improvement or circumstantial change, but with running to the cross where Jesus—our great High Priest—has already made the once-for-all atonement that secures God's favor forever.

Tuesday [Leviticus 1](#)

The burnt offering consumed entirely on the altar symbolized complete surrender and worship rising to God. The exiles offered these sacrifices (Ezra 3:3-4) not after rebuilding, but at the **beginning**, signaling that their work would flow from reconciled hearts. When we have been reconciled to God through Christ, our hands naturally move toward the work He calls us to in the world—worship becomes embodied in obedience, not trapped in sentiment.

Wednesday [Psalm 100](#)

This psalm calls us to enter God's gates with thanksgiving and gratitude—a inward posture. Yet the exiles showed us that such gratitude immediately became **construction**, **rebuilding**, **tangible work** in Jerusalem's ruins. Grateful worship is not complete until it flows into the kingdom work God has placed before us; the same hands that lift in praise must lift stones and lay foundations.

Thursday [Zechariah 4:10](#)

Zechariah's vision honors the 'day of small things'—the very modest foundation of the second temple that drew weeping from those who remembered the first. God speaks through Zechariah to assure that He **delights** in small beginnings because He sees them through to completion. When our lives lie in ruins and we feel capable only of humble, faltering steps toward renewal, we stand in the exact place where God works most powerfully.

Friday [Romans 8:28](#)

Paul's promise that God works **all things** together for good for those who love Him echoes through the exiles' return: captivity, ruin, and return all served God's purpose to humble His people and restore them to worship. Our own ruins—failures, sins, broken circumstances—are woven into the same sovereign pattern; God is renewing us through repentance, worship, and faithful work, just as He renewed Israel, and He will complete what He has begun.

Memory Verse

And they sang responsively, praising and giving thanks to the LORD, 'For he is good, for his steadfast love endures forever toward Israel.' And all the people shouted with a great shout when they praised the LORD, because the foundation of the house of the LORD was laid.
— **Ezra 3:11**

This verse captures the sermon's central claim that worship is where restoration begins and that worship produces grateful celebration—the people's responsive praise and thanksgiving demonstrate that right worship of God is the necessary foundation for any rebuilding. The verse embodies the pattern Ryan Chase emphasizes: reconciliation with God first, then joyful action in the world.

Family Conversation

When You Don't Know Where to Start

In the sermon, we heard that when the Jewish people came back to Jerusalem and saw their city completely destroyed, they didn't start by picking up hammers and building right away. Instead, they built an altar first and offered sacrifices to God. Why do you think they chose to worship God before they started rebuilding their homes and their temple? What does that tell us about what matters most when everything feels broken?

WORKS FOR AGES 7+; YOUNGER CHILDREN CAN LISTEN AND OFFER SIMPLE OBSERVATIONS WHILE OLDER KIDS AND TEENS GRAPPLE WITH THE THEOLOGICAL PRIORITY

For parents: This prompt invites your family to think about what the people in Ezra's day did first when their city lay in ruins—and what that teaches us when our own lives feel broken or messy. Listen for whether kids instinctively reach for 'fixing' things or whether they can grasp why worship comes first.

For Couples

Worship First, Then Rebuild

What area of your life feels most 'ruined' right now—and did the sermon help you see that returning to worship with Jesus might be the actual first step, rather than trying to fix everything at once?

When we look at our marriage, where have we been trying to rebuild or repair without first seeking reconciliation with God together through worship and repentance—and how might our posture change if we made that the starting point?

Who among us needs the other to pray that we would run to the cross more quickly when we stumble, and what specifically can each of us ask the Lord to do in the other's heart this week?

Questions, or something we got wrong? Reply to this email, or use "Suggest a change" on your sermon page.